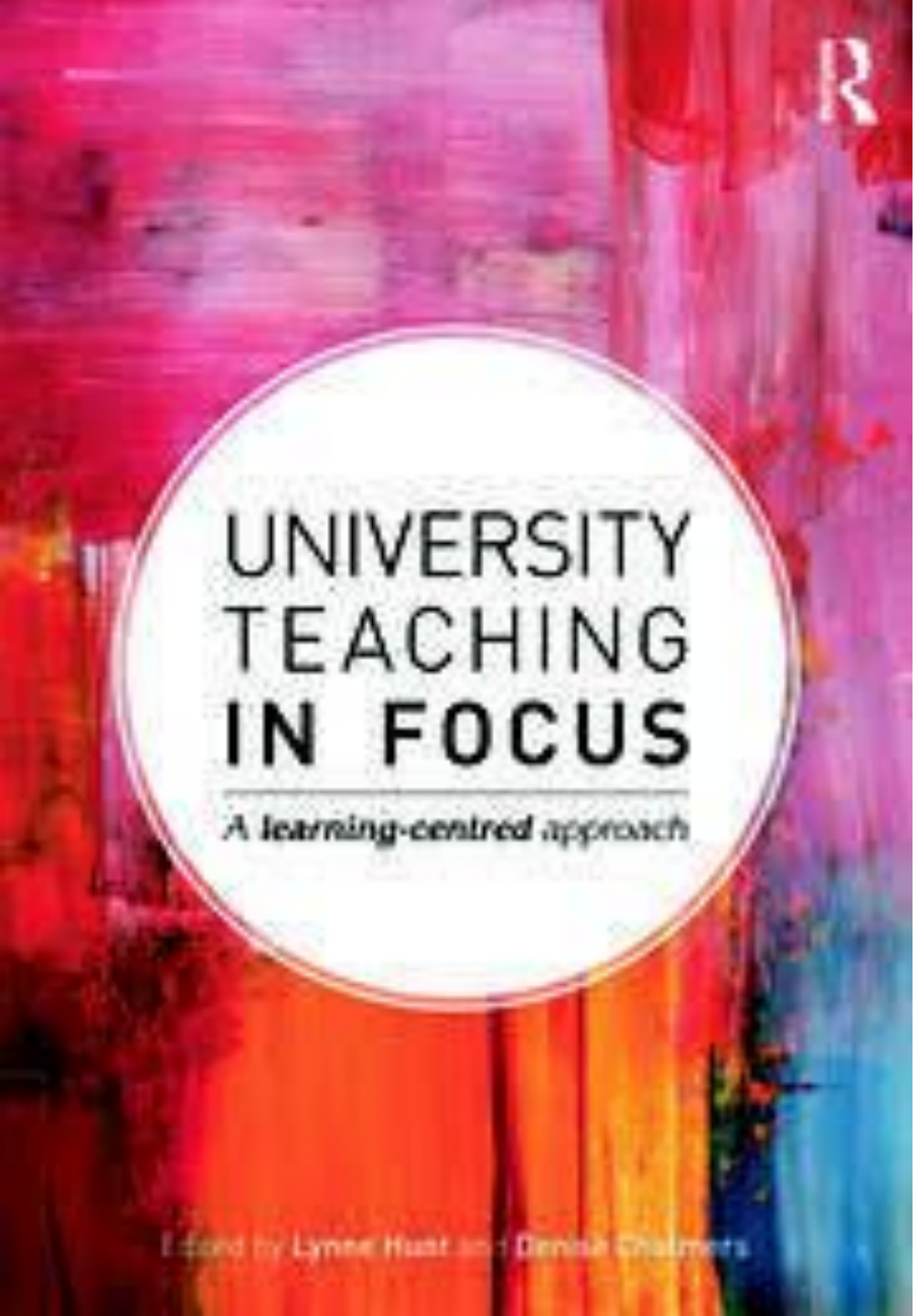
Criticism on behaviorism

Group n.5



UNDERSTANDING LEARNING: THEORIES AND CRITIQUE

Martyn Stewart

Criticisms of behaviorist learning theories

While leading to enormous leaps forward in our understanding of learning as a process, especially in skills acquisition, the rigidity of the methods and their ‘input–output’ analyses proved a limitation. The researcher, as a distant observer of behavioural change, essentially reduced behaviour to correlations between stimuli and internal responses, viewing the mind somewhat as a blank canvas. Critics highlighted this view of human learning as one-dimensional and mechanical (Myers

1988).

The teacher-centric and outcome-based view of learning is also criticised for prioritising short-term attainment of learning outcomes because, irrespective of the

teaching method, the education programme was assumed a success once targets

had been met. However, while rote learning is effective at achieving results in the

short term, retention over the longer term using this method is questionable.

Other major criticisms concerned the naïve generalisation of findings from

animal experiments to human learning (Chomsky 1959; Piaget 1952; Nye 1979).

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